The rising tide of “metaphysical and theologising thought” that the members of the circle pit themselves against in their manifesto was not merely religious. German idealism was among the most influential styles of philosophy in Central Europe at the time—and it was entirely incompatible with the Vienna Circle’s down-to-earth empiricism. German idealists believed in the primacy of ideas over the material world; they were the intellectual descendants of G. W. F. Hegel, the famous German philosopher of the early nineteenth century. Hegel believed in a world-spirit that arises out of the course of history and steers it to some ultimate end. Prone to grand pronouncements about the nature of reality, the positivists found him needlessly vague and difficult to understand. For example, in one of his best-known works, *Lectures on the Philosophy of History,* Hegel proclaimed that “reason… is substance, as well as infinite power, its own infinite material underlying all the natural and spiritual life; as also the infinite form, that which sets the material in motion.” To the positivists, this seemed like nonsense.

In addition to Hegel and his followers, there was a contemporary German philosopher, Martin Heidegger, whose philosophy ran counter to the Vienna Circle’s ideals. Though Heidegger disagreed with Hegel on many subjects, they both emphasized abstract ideas and intuition over empirical data and material substance, exactly the reverse of the Vienna Circle’s ideals.

The Vienna Circle manifesto was a call to arms against what it perceived as regressive, involuted, and deliberately obscure philosophy. “Neatness and clarity are striven for, and dark distances and unfathomable depths rejected,” it proclaimed. The work of Hegel, Heidegger, and their ilk, removed from the everyday world of sight and sound, was dismissed as “metaphysics.” “The view which attributes to intuition a superior and more penetrating power of knowing, capable of leading beyond the contents of sense experience and not to be confined by the shackles of conceptual thought—this view is rejected.… [T]here is no way to genuine knowledge other than the way of experience; there is no realm of ideas that stands over or beyond experience.” In place of idealism or theology, the Vienna Circle promoted a “scientific world-conception,” with two important features. “*First* [the scientific world-conception] is *empiricist* and *positivist:* there is knowledge only from experience.… This sets the limits for the content of